THE RAMBAM'S EIGHT CHAPTERS - SHEMONAH PERAKIM

Who Is a Hasid, and Is Self-Denial Holy?

The Rambam's Eight Chapters, Chapter 4, Part 2

Sefer: Shemonah Perakim (the Eight Chapters) by the Rambam **Chapter:** Chapter 4, second half (up to the Nazir) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Tuesday-night series on the Shemonah Perakim, Tuesday 5 March 2024

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Review

The Rabbi reviewed the series and the first half of Chapter 4. The Rambam's ideal is equilibrium in faculty 4 of the soul, the seat of our desires. Every trait has two defects, excess and deficiency, and both are equally defective. A reckless person is as far from courage as a coward. Someone who gives away too much is as far from generosity as a miser. The cure is to go to the other extreme for a time, like cooling a person with a high fever, until it starts to become a habit, and then to return to the middle. "Something is bent one way. In order to bend it back, we have to bend it the other way."

Not all extremes are equal to cure

Last week ended with a question: if you cannot be at 50, is 75 or 25 better? Now the Rambam gives the caveat. When we treat an extravagant person, we make him act with some stinginess, but not as much as we make a miser act with extravagance. The reason: it is easier to come back from excess to the middle than from deficiency.

The Rambam's example concerns pleasure. A person who cuts himself off from the pleasures of the world, which is wrong, finds it easier to return to the middle than someone immersed in desire. So we make the one immersed in desire work harder.

The Rabbi put a case to the class: a reckless person at 75 and a cowardly one at 25. Who has to work harder? The participants answered that it is easier for the reckless person to calm down than for the cautious one to start taking risks. The Rabbi agreed: cowardice is a deficiency, recklessness an excess. So the coward will be made to take risks more, and for longer, than the reckless person is made to be cautious.

The same applies to kindness. The unkind person has to work harder than the one who is too kind. That is why, as the Rabbi had stressed last week, we must first notice that we have a problem (Chapter 3), and then identify which side it is on. That tells us how much work it will take.

The Rambam's definition of a hasid

Who can know exactly where 50 is? Only a true hakham can live at the middle, more or less, in all his traits. Even then, it is not something you reach once and keep. The Rabbi compared it to prophecy, which a person does not attain once and hold for life. It takes constant work, and that, he said, is what life is about.

So the Rambam introduces **hasidut**, a word the Rabbi said is badly misused today. For the Rambam, hasidut means leaning slightly to one extreme, the one from which it is easier to come back. If I cannot tell whether I am being too kind or too unkind, I lean a little towards too kind. The Rambam calls this *lifnim mishurat hadin*, going beyond the letter of the law. The pious lean slightly: - towards restraint rather than indulgence, - towards risk rather than cowardice, - towards kindness rather than unkindness, - towards self-effacement rather than arrogance.

"Slightly" is the key word. The Rabbi's example: kosher ice cream, six hours after a meat meal, on an ordinary day. There is no reason not to have it. Say a berakhah and enjoy it. But if I notice I have been watching the clock too closely, I might skip it today, for today only, as a lesson in self-discipline. That is leaning to 45. Deciding never to eat ice cream again is going to zero, and that is absurd.

A participant with a banking background was asked whether the risk principle works in real life. He said a bank makes money by taking risk, and the question is your risk appetite: from a balanced position you might take a little more, but not jump to 75 or 80. The Rabbi agreed: 50 to 55 or 60.

So in the Rabbi's reading: the ideal is the hakham at 50. In reality that is very hard, so we become hasidim and lean very slightly towards the side that is easier to correct.

Ascetics and the Hasidei Ashkenaz

The Rambam next takes on a sensitive issue of his time. The Rabbi gave background on the Hasidei Ashkenaz, a medieval pious movement in Germany and France whose members lived very ascetic lives and practised severe penances. He mentioned the Sefer HaRokeah of Rabbi Elazar of Worms as one work that describes such penances, including rolling in the snow.

Based on what we have learnt, is this the proper way? Of course not, said the Rabbi. The Torah never asked for it.

The Rambam writes that we have heard of pious people who fasted, rose at night, avoided meat and wine, separated from their wives, wore rough wool and even went to live in mountains and deserts. He explains that they did it as **medicine**, to cure themselves, and for a limited time. When they saw the society around them corrupting them, they withdrew, as Yirmeyahu said: "If only I were in the desert... and could leave my people."

The trouble comes when fools see the pious doing this and think it is the ideal way to live. They afflict themselves all their lives, thinking it brings them closer to God, "as if God really wants you to hate your body."

The Rambam's analogy: a man who knows no medicine sees a doctor give strong drugs to very sick patients, and they recover. He concludes that if these drugs saved the sick, they will

make him even healthier. He takes them and becomes ill. The Rabbi's modern version: taking antibiotics when you are well. The same happens with the soul when people copy a cure as if it were a way of life.

The Rabbi offered some context. The Rambam lived in Spain and Egypt, under Islam, where such practices were foreign. In Christian Europe, the highest religious ideal was the celibate life of the monastery and the hermit, and the Rabbi said some accused the Hasidei Ashkenaz of being influenced by this. He suggested the Rambam had heard of these practices and wrote "in certain places and certain times" with them in mind. He gave his own view that, from reading their works, many of them seem to have valued self-affliction for its own sake, which the Rambam would reject outright.

The Torah is the middle path

The Rambam then says that our perfect Torah never asks for self-affliction. He quotes Tehillim: "The Torah of HaShem is perfect, restoring the soul." Its way is the middle path: eat and drink in moderation, have relations within marriage in moderation, live among people. No one is told to live in a monastery or as a hermit.

The Nazir

The Rambam's proof is the Nazir. When the Nazir completes his term, he brings a sacrifice. Hazal ask: what did he sin? He denied himself wine. If one who denied himself only wine needs atonement, how much more so one who denies himself everything.

The Rabbi noted that the Nazir is also called holy, which seems to contradict the Rambam. Not so, he said. A Nazir vows for a limited period, by default thirty days. He is holy because he recognised a flaw in himself, a pull towards pleasure, and took steps to correct it. That is exactly the work of Chapter 4. But the abstinence itself is not the ideal, because God gave us the pleasures of the world to enjoy. So he brings an offering at the end. A permanent Nazir would not, for the Rambam, be following the ideal.

Looking ahead

The Rabbi said the Rambam will next show how the misvot are designed to keep us balanced. He planned for the following week to finish Chapter 4 and then discuss a modern idea, polarity management, comparing it with the Rambam and Aristotle and applying it practically. "If we were just to learn the eight chapters together without putting them into practice, then we'd miss the point."

Summary

- Both extremes are equally defective, but it is easier to return from excess than from deficiency, so the deficient person has to work harder.
- For the Rambam, a hasid leans slightly towards the side that is easier to correct; this is *lifnim mishurat hadin*. Slightly, not to the extreme.
- The pious who fasted or withdrew from society did so as temporary medicine; copying them as a way of life is like a healthy man taking strong drugs.

- The Torah's own path is moderation within society, not monastic self-denial.
- The Nazir is holy for correcting himself, yet brings an offering for denying himself what God permitted.

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